

1973 年巴菲特致股东的信

翻译: Rick http://blog.sina.com.cn/s/blog_a3453d2201015q5j.html

巴菲特购买蓝带印花公司的时候，该公司的主业已经开始出现大幅下滑。但是巴菲特看重的是其两个子公司：喜诗糖果和 Wesco 金融公司。

巴菲特收购多元零售公司，并不是看重其主业：女装连锁零售店。而是看重其持有蓝带印花公司 16% 的股权。

To the Stockholders of Berkshire Hathaway Inc.:

Our financial results for 1973 were satisfactory, with operating earnings of \$11,930,592, producing a return of 17.4% on beginning stockholders' equity.

Although operating earnings improved from \$11.43 to \$12.18 per share, earnings on equity decreased from the 19.8% of 1972. This decline occurred because the gain in earnings was not commensurate with the increase in shareholders' investment. We had forecast in last year's report that such a decline was likely. Unfortunately, our forecast proved to be correct.

致伯克希尔股东：

1973 年的财务结果令人满意，我们的营业利润为 1193 万元，相对于年初的股东权益产生了 17.4% 的回报。虽然每股的营业利润从 11.43 美元提高到了每股 12.18 美元，ROE 却从 1972 年的 19.8% 下降到了 1973 年的 17.4%。

下降的原因是盈利的增长未跟上股东权益的增长。在去年的年报里，我们曾预测 ROE 可能会出现下降，如今不幸言中。

Our textile, banking, and most insurance operations had good years, but certain segments of the insurance business turned in poor results. Overall, our insurance business continues to be a most attractive area in which to employ capital.

Management's objective is to achieve a return on capital over the long term which averages somewhat higher than that of American industry generally—while utilizing sound accounting and debt policies. We have achieved this goal in the last few years, and are trying to take those steps which will enable us to maintain this performance in the future. Prospects for 1974 indicate some further decline in rate of return on our enlarged capital base.

我们的纺织业务、银行业务和大部分保险业务都表现得不错，但是一部分保险业务业绩比较糟糕。总体而言，我们的保险业务在配置资本上还是一个很具有吸引力的领域。管理层的目标是：在长期内，投入资本的回报率高于美国产业的平均水平（在严格的会计准则和负债政策的条件下）。在过去的几年，我们达到了这一目标，我们期望在未来的几年也能达到这一目标。1974 年，由于我们资本规模的扩大，ROE 可能会进一步下降。

Textile Operations

Textile demand remained unusually strong throughout 1973. Our main problems revolved around shortages of fiber, which complicated operations and resulted in something less than full utilization of loom capacity. Prices of some fibers skyrocketed during the year. Cost of Living Council regulations prevented the pricing of many finished products at levels of some of our competitors. However, profits were reasonably commensurate with our capital investment, although below those that apparently might have been achieved had we been able to price at market levels.

对纺织品的需求继续在 1973 年保持强劲，这并不多见。我们的主要问题是原材料短缺，这使得我们织布机的产能并没有得到完全的利用。一些原材料的价格在 1973 年大幅直线上涨。生活成本委员会制定了规则，不允许我们的产成品的价格定得和竞争对手一样高。在这种情况下，我们获得的利润明显比如果产品能够自由定价时要低，但是和我们投入的资本相比，我们的获利相当合理。

The textile business has been highly cyclical and price controls may have served to cut down some of the hills while still leaving us with the inevitable valleys. Because of the extraordinary price rises in raw materials during 1973, which show signs of continuing in 1974, we have elected to adopt the "lifo" method of inventory pricing. This method more nearly matches current costs against current revenues, and minimizes inventory "profits" included in reported earnings. Further information on this change is included in the footnotes to our financial statements.

纺织业务是高度周期性的业务，价格管制将我们的盈利高峰削平了，但是当不可避免地出现盈利低点时却没人管我们。1973 年原材料的价格上涨了很多，1974 年价格上涨仍在持续，我们将在我们的存货上更改记账方法，采取“后进先出法”。这种记账方法将使得收入和成本更加匹配，减少了盈利中因存货（价格上涨而）产生的利润。关于会计方法改变的详细情况参见财务报表的附注。

Insurance Operations

During 1973, Jack Ringwalt retired as President of National Indemnity Company after an absolutely brilliant record since founding the business in 1940. He was succeeded by Phil Liesche who, fortunately for us, possesses the same underwriting and managerial philosophy that worked so well for Jack. Our traditional business, specialized auto and general liability lines conducted through National Indemnity

Company and National Fire and Marine Insurance Company, had an exceptionally fine underwriting year during 1973. We again experienced a decline in volume.

保险业务

1973 年，国民赔偿保险公司的 Jack 在总裁的位置上退休了。他于 1940 年创办了这个公司，这些年取得了优异的业绩记录。Phi 将接他的班，担任总裁。对我们来说，幸运的是，Phil 和 Jack 共事多年，拥有和 Jack 相同的管理理念。我们的传统保险领域，车险和普通责任险，通过国民赔偿保险公司和国民火灾和海难保险公司来承保，在 1973 年表现良好。我们的承保业务量又经历了下降。（根据 2012 年公司的官网，这两个保险公司同属 National Indemnity Group，这个集团的旗舰业务是 National Indemnity Company。rick）

Competition was intense, and we passed up the chance to match rate-cutting by more optimistic underwriters. There currently are faint indications that some of these competitors are learning of the inadequacy of their rates (and also of their loss Reserves) which may result in easing of market pressures as the year develops. If so, we may again experience volume increases.

竞争很激烈，我们将承保业务量让给了乐观的同行，他们的费率较低。这些竞争对手将会发现他们目前所收取的费率是不足的，他们同时也会发现他们的损失准备也是不足的。随着时间的推移（这些情况会暴露出来），市场的压力就会减轻了（指保费费率偏低的情况）。这个时候，我们又将经历保费收入的大幅增长。

Our reinsurance operation had a somewhat similar year—good underwriting experience, but difficulty in maintaining previous volume levels. This operation, guided by the tireless and well- directed efforts of George Young, has been a major profit producer since its inception in 1969. Our "home state" insurance companies made excellent progress in Nebraska and Minnesota, with both good growth in volume and acceptable loss ratios. We began operations late in the year in Iowa. To date, our big problem has been Texas. In that state we virtually had to start over during 1973 as the initial management we selected proved incapable of underwriting successfully. The Texas experience has been expensive, and we still have our work cut out for us. Overall, however, the home state operation appears to have a promising potential.

我们再保险业务的情况和保险业务类似，拥有良好的承保业绩，但是保费的收入下降了。我们的再保险业务，由不知疲倦的 George Young 所带领，从 1969 年诞生起，就成了我们主要的利润来源。我们自有的保险公司，在内布拉斯加州和明尼苏达州取得了重要进展，保费收入增长不错，承保损失也在可接受范围之内。我们在 1973 年末进入爱荷华州。到目前为止，我们最大的问题在德州。在德州，我们最初的管理团队在承保业务上被证明是没有能力的，所以在 1973 年我们在

这个州重新开始。德州的经验教训很昂贵，我们还有很多事情要做。总体而言，我们自有的保险公司的经营前景看起来还不错。

Our specialized urban auto operation, Home and Automobile Insurance Company, experienced very poor underwriting in Chicago during 1973. It would appear that rates are inadequate in our primary Cook County marketing area, although the current energy situation confuses the picture.

家庭汽车保险公司，我们专营市区汽车保险业务的部门，1973 年在芝加哥地区的承保业务业绩很糟。在我们的主要经营地区，库克县，我们所收取的保费费率太低，虽然目前的油价较高，使情况变得复杂。

The question is whether possible lowered accident frequency because of reduced driving will more than offset continuing inflation in medical and repair costs, as well as jury awards. We believe that inflation will hurt us more than reduced driving will help us, but some of our competitors appear to believe otherwise. Home and Auto expanded into Florida and California during the year, but it is too early to know how these moves will prove out financially. A contributing factor in our unsatisfactory earnings at Home and Auto during 1973 was an accounting system which was not bringing information to management on a sufficiently timely basis.

问题在于因为油价较高导致的驾驶次数的降低，因而事故率可能会出现下降，由此带来的好处是否能覆盖因为通货膨胀导致的医疗成本、维修成本和法庭成本的上升。我们相信，通货膨胀的影响更大；而我们的竞争对手相信高油价的影响更大。（竞争对手相信高油价带来的好处更大，所以降低了保费费率。也许家庭汽车保险公司也因此受压降低了费率，所以导致承保业绩很糟糕。rick）在 1973 年，家庭汽车保险公司的业务拓展到了佛罗里达州和加州，目前下结论还为时过早，不知道最终的财务结果如何。1973 年，家庭汽车保险公司的业绩较差，一个重要的原因是公司的财务会计系统存在问题，它不能将公司的真实信息及时地传递给管理层。（以前年报，巴菲特对 Vic 大加赞赏，今年不提了，rick）

On the investment side of our insurance operation, we made substantial additional commitments in common stocks during 1973. We had significant unrealized depreciation—over \$12 million—in our common stock holdings at year-end, as indicated in our financial statements. Nevertheless, we believe that our common stock portfolio at cost represents good value in terms of intrinsic business worth. In spite of the large unrealized loss at year-end, we would expect satisfactory results from the portfolio over the longer term.

在我们保险业务的浮存金投资方面，我们在 1973 年做了大量的股票投资。从财务报表上，我们可以看到，在 1973 年底，**我们有大量的未实现的折旧，超过 1200 万美元**。然而，我们相信**以成本计价的普通股**反应这些股票的内在价值。**尽管在年末，这些股票在账面上有大量的浮亏，我们预期在长期内我们的股票组合会产生令人满意的回报。**

Banking Operations

The Illinois National Bank & Trust Co. of Rockford again had a record year in 1973. Average deposits were approximately \$130 million, of which approximately 60% were time deposits. Interest rates were increased substantially in the important consumer savings area when regulatory maximums were raised at mid-year. Despite this mix heavily weighted toward interest bearing deposits, our operating earnings after taxes (including a new Illinois state income tax) were again over 2.1% of average deposits. We continue to be the largest bank in Rockford. We continue to maintain unusual liquidity. We continue to meet the increasing loan demands of our customers. And we continue to maintain our unusual profitability. This is a direct tribute to the abilities of Gene Abegg, Chairman, who has been running the Bank since it opened its doors in 1931, and Bob Kline, our President.

银行业务

1973 年，位于 Rockford 的伊利诺伊国民银行又取得了好成绩。年内银行的平均存款达到 1.3 亿美元，大约 60% 为定期存款。在我们主要的储户区域，利率大幅上升，原因是年中的时候最高利率上限提高了。尽管这个存款组合中付息的存款占大多数，我们的税后利润占平均存款的比例仍然达到了 2.1%（该州 1973 年适用新的所得税税率）。我们仍然是 Rockford 最大的银行，并且我们保持高水平的流动性。我们继续满足消费者不断增长的贷款需求，并且继续取得不同寻常的利润率。这些都归功于我们的主席 Gene 和总裁 Bob 的领导有方。从 1931 年这家银行开业其，Gene 就管理者这家银行。

Merger With Diversified Retailing Company, Inc.

Your Directors have approved the merger of Diversified Retailing Company, Inc. into Berkshire Hathaway Inc. on terms involving issuance of 195,000 shares of Berkshire stock for the 1,000,000 shares of Diversified stock outstanding. Because Diversified and its subsidiaries own 109,551 shares of Berkshire, the net increase in the number of shares of Berkshire outstanding after giving effect to this transaction will not exceed 85,449. Various regulatory approvals must be obtained before this merger can be completed, and proxy material will be submitted to you later this year so that you may vote upon it. Diversified Retailing Company, Inc., through subsidiaries, operates a chain of popular-priced women's apparel stores and also conducts a reinsurance business. In the opinion of management, its most important asset is 16% of the stock of Blue Chip Stamps.

与多元零售公司合并

伯克希尔的董事会已经批准了伯克希尔和多元零售公司合并。合并的方案是：伯克希尔向多元零售公司的股东发行 19.5 万股换取多元零售公司发行在外的 100 万股股票。因为多元零售公司及其子公司拥有伯克希尔 10.9551 万股的股票，所以本次换股后，伯克希尔发行在外股票的净增加量不会超过 8.5449 万股。我们需要得到多个批准才能完成这次合并。今年晚些时候我们将给股东寄发代理文件，以便股东进行投票。

多元零售公司以及它的子公司，拥有销售女装的连锁零售店，同时他们也经营再保险业务。在伯克希尔管理层的眼里，多元零售公司最重要的资产是拥有蓝带印花公司 16% 的股份。

Blue Chip Stamps

Our holdings of stock in Blue Chip Stamps at year-end amounted to approximately 19% of that company's outstanding shares. Since year-end, we have increased our holdings so that they now represent approximately 22.5%: implementation of the proposed merger with Diversified Retailing Company, Inc. would increase this figure to about 38.5%.

在去年年末，我们持有蓝带印花公司大约 19% 的股份。今年以来，我们增加了我们在这家公司的持股数量，目前总的持股比例大约为 22.5%。如果合并多元零售公司的方案得到批准的话，我们在这个公司的持股比例将上升到 38.5%。

Our equity in earnings of Blue Chip Stamps became significant for the first time in 1973, and posed an accounting question as to just what period's earnings should be recognized by Berkshire Hathaway Inc. as applicable to the financial statements covered by this annual report. Blue Chip's fiscal year ends on the Saturday closest to February 28, or two months after the fiscal year-end of Berkshire Hathaway Inc. Or, viewed alternatively, their year ends ten months prior to Berkshire Hathaway's.

在 1973 年，我们按比例持有的蓝带印花公司的利润对我们而言首次变得重要起来。但是这同样带来了一个会计上的问题：蓝带印花公司哪个期间的盈利应该被合并到伯克希尔里来。蓝带印花公司的财年在 2 月 28 日附近的那个周日结束，而伯克希尔的财年在 12 月 31 日结束。蓝带印花公司的财政年度比伯克希尔晚 2 个月或者说早 10 个月。

An acceptable accounting choice for us, and one which, if made, would not have required an auditor's disclaimer as to scope, was to recognize in our 1973 income an equity of \$632,000 in Blue Chip's earnings for their year ended March 3, 1973 with regard to the fewer shares of Blue Chip we owned during this earlier period. But such

an approach seemed at odds with reality, and would have meant a ten month lag each year in the future.

一个可以接受的方案是在我们 1973 年的年报中，采用蓝带印花公司截至 1973 年 3 月 3 日的年度数据，这样我们按比例持有的盈利将会是 63.2 万美金。但是这样做会显得和实际情况有较大出入，我们那个时候的持股比例较少，而且两个年报之间有 10 个月的时滞。如果我们选择这种方案，这将意味着以后都会存在 10 个月的时滞。

Therefore, we chose to reflect as 1973 income our equity of \$1,008,000 in Blue Chip's earnings based upon unaudited interim earnings through November as publicly reported by Blue Chip Stamps and with regard to our shareholdings during 1973. Because we made this choice of unaudited but current figures, as opposed to the alternative of audited but far from current figures, Peat, Marwick, Mitchell & Co. were unable to express an opinion on our 1973 earnings attributable to Blue Chip Stamps.

因此，我们选择了另一个方案，由于蓝筹印花公司也披露中报，但是未经审计。我们采用中报的数据，这样在 1973 年将有 100.8 万美元的盈利反应在伯克希尔的账上。由于我们采用了未经审计但是离我们年报截止日期较近的数字，而不是采用经过审计离我们年报截止日期较远的数字，伯克希尔的审计师无法就我们应占蓝筹印花公司的利润发布审计意见。

The annual report of Blue Chip Stamps, which will contain financial statements for the year ending March 2, 1974 audited by Price, Waterhouse and Company, will be available in early May. Any shareholder of Berkshire Hathaway Inc. who desires an annual report of Blue Chip Stamps may obtain it at that time by writing Mr. Robert H. Bird, Secretary, Blue Chip Stamps, 5801 South Eastern Avenue, Los Angeles, California 90040.

在 5 月初，我们就可以提供蓝带印花公司的年报了。年报里有其财务报表的数据，最近年度的财报截止日期为 1974 年 3 月 2 日，审计师为普华永道。伯克希尔的股东如果想要看蓝带印花公司的年报可以在任何时间写信给公司的秘书伯德先生。公司的地址是：Blue Chip Stamps, 5801 South Eastern Avenue, Los Angeles, California 90040.

Blue Chip's trading stamp business has declined drastically over the past year or so, but it has important sources of earning power in its See's Candy Shops subsidiary as well as Wesco Financial Corporation, a 54% owned subsidiary engaged in the savings and loan business. We expect Blue Chip Stamps to achieve satisfactory earnings in future years related to capital employed, although certainly at a much lower level than

would have been achieved if the trading stamp business had been maintained at anything close to former levels. Your Chairman is on the Board of Directors of Blue Chip Stamps, as well as Wesco Financial Corporation, and is Chairman of the Board of See's Candy Shops Incorporated. Operating management of all three entities is in the hands of first class, able, experienced executives.

在过去几年里，蓝带印花公司自身的业务出现了大幅的下滑，但是它仍然有两个重要的盈利来源：喜诗糖果和公司持股 54% 的 Wesco 金融公司（主要从事储蓄和贷款业务）。我们期待蓝带印花公司能为我们带来令人满意的回报，当然这个回报水平肯定比如果现在蓝带印花公司自身业务和以前一样好的时候低。你们的主席（巴菲特自己）是蓝带印花公司的董事，也是 Wesco 金融公司的董事，同时还是喜诗糖果公司的董事会主席。这三个公司的管理团队都是第一流的，他们非常有经验、有能力。（蓝带印花公司的主要业务是和超市或其他零售店合作，提高他们顾客的忠诚度。顾客在零售店购物后，根据他们的购物金额，可以得到一些类似邮票的小纸带，回家后他们得花时间把这些小纸带贴在一本书上，然后用这本书去对应的零售店换取指定的商品。类似现在的顾客忠诚计划。rick）

Sun Newspapers, Inc.

In the 1969 annual report we commented on the purchase of Sun Newspapers Inc., a group of weekly papers published in the metropolitan Omaha area. Since that time we have not commented on their operations in the text of our annual reports, nor have we consolidated their financial results since the operation, because of the small investment involved, has been "financially insignificant." During 1973 it was made quite apparent that such insignificance did not extend to publishing quality. On May 7th Sun Newspapers was awarded a Pulitzer Prize for local investigative reporting (the first time in history that a weekly had won in this category) for its special section of March 30, 1972 relating to Boys Town.

太阳新闻报

我们在 1969 年的年报里提到了我们购买了太阳新闻报公司。这家公司拥有在奥马哈大都会地区的几份周报。从那以后，我们再也没有在年报里提到过这个公司，我们也没有把他们的财务情况并表，因为我们持有的股份数量很少，在财务上并不重要。在 1973 年，对我们而言，这个公司在财务上不重要，并不代表其质量不行。在 5 月 7 号，太阳新闻报因为其在本地的调查报告而获得普利策新闻奖，这是历史上首次有周报获得这个奖项。有关这篇报道的详情请参见 1972 年 3 月 30 日关于儿童城的新闻。（儿童城是一家慈善组织，巴菲特的父亲曾帮助过该机构，该机构声名大噪以后，接受的捐款很多，花在受捐对象上的钱却很少。太阳报的记者收集了证据，对此事进行了报道。rick）

We reported the extraordinary contrast between decreasing services and mounting wealth that had taken place since Father Flanagan's death in 1948. In addition to the

Pulitzer Prize, the reporting job also won the Public Service Award of Sigma Delta Chi, the national society of professional journalists, as well as seven other national awards. Our congratulations go to Paul Williams, Editor, and Stan Lipsey, Publisher, as well as the entire editorial staff of Sun Newspapers for their achievement, which vividly illustrated that size need not be equated with significance in publishing.

自 1948 年 Flanagan 神父去世以后，儿童城接受的捐款越来越多，而他们提供的服务却越来越少。太阳报对此进行了报道。除了获得普利策新闻奖以外，太阳报还获得了公共服务奖和其他几个奖项。我们在此对编辑保罗、出版人斯坦以及太阳新闻报的所有采编团队表示祝贺！他们所取得的成就证明了在出版行业中，小报也能发挥重大的作用。

Warren E. Buffett
Chairman of the Board
March 29, 1974